

Chicago Tribune



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BREAKING NEWS AT CHICAGOTRIBUNE.COM

House out early amid Epstein clash

DOJ top deputy says prosecutors want to interview Maxwell

By **Stephen Groves and Lisa Mascaro**
Associated Press

WASHINGTON — House Speaker Mike Johnson rebuffed pressure to act on the investigation into Jeffrey Epstein, instead sending members home early for a monthlong break from Washington after the week’s legislative agenda was upended by Republican members who are clamoring for a vote.

Johnson, a Republican from Louisiana, said Tuesday morning that he wants to give the White House “space” to release the

Epstein information on its own, despite the bipartisan push for legislation that aims to force the release of more documents.

“There’s no purpose for the Congress to push an administration to do something they’re already doing,” Johnson said at his weekly press conference, his last before lawmakers depart Wednesday from Washington for their traditional August recess.

Meanwhile, the Department of Justice wants to interview Epstein’s former girlfriend, Ghislaine Maxwell, who was convicted of helping the financier sexually abuse underage girls and is serving

a lengthy prison sentence, a senior official said Tuesday.

If Maxwell “has information about anyone who has committed crimes against victims, the FBI and the DOJ will hear what she has to say,” Deputy Attorney General Todd Blanche said in a post on X, adding that President Donald Trump “has told us to release all credible evidence.” A lawyer for Maxwell confirmed there were discussions with the government.

The overture to attorneys for Maxwell, who in 2022 was sentenced to 20 years in prison, is

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House Speaker Mike Johnson speaks to reporters Tuesday at the Capitol after calling an early recess. **J. SCOTT APPLEWHITE/AP**



Through the Chicago Cancer Health Equity Collaborative Fellows program at Northwestern University, Eric Mun, who’s interested in going to medical school, takes part in a CPR demonstration and a tour at a Northwestern surgical bio skills simulation lab on Monday. **ANTONIO PEREZ/TRIBUNE**

Aspiring physicians thrown into financial uncertainty

‘People are panicking’: Changes to federal student loans leave med school hopefuls scrambling

By **Kate Armanini**
Chicago Tribune

Twenty-year-old Eric Mun didn’t want to believe it: Only one kid in the family could make it to medical school — and it wasn’t going to be him.

Mun had done everything right. He graduated high school with honors, earned a scholarship at Northwestern University and breezed through his biology courses.

He immigrated to Alabama from Korea as a toddler. From the quiet stretches of the South, he dreamed of helping patients in a pressed white coat.

But dreams don’t pay tuition. And with new borrowing limits, Mun’s family can only support one child through school.

“My parents already implied that my older brother is probably going to be the one that gets to go,” Mun said.

President Donald Trump’s sweeping “big, beautiful” tax and spending bill, signed into law earlier this month, imposes strict new caps on federal student loans, capping borrowing for professional schools at \$50,000 per year. The measure particularly affects medical students, whose tuition often exceeds \$300,000 over four years.

Aspiring physicians like Mun have been thrown into financial uncertainty. Many members of the medical community say the measures will send shock waves through a system already laden with economic barriers, discouraging low-income students from pursuing a medical degree.

“It might mean there are people who want to be doctors that can’t be doctors because they can’t afford it,” said Richard Anderson, president of the Illinois State Medical Society.

Before the passage of Trump’s budget bill, the Grad PLUS loan program allowed graduate students to borrow their insti-

tution’s total cost of attendance, including living expenses. The program was slashed as part of a broader overhaul to the federal student loan system.

Now, beginning July 1, 2026, most graduate students will be capped at \$20,500 in federal loans per year, with a total limit of \$100,000. Students in professional schools, like medical, dental or law school, will face the \$50,000 annual cap and a total limit of \$200,000.

Mun’s parents work at an automobile assembly plant. Through-out high school, he knew he

Turn to Loans, Page 6

Sticker shock for ComEd customers

Some see big bill hikes as supply rate jumps, heat wave converge

By **Robert Channick**
Chicago Tribune

The first ComEd bills with a massive baked-in supply rate increase are hitting home for Chicago-area customers, and after a record heat wave in June, they may be in for some sticker shock.

The spike in the wholesale cost of electricity, which ComEd buys at an annual auction and then passes through to its customers, paired with increased energy usage, added \$67.28 month-over-month to the average June 30 bill, the utility said.

Some ComEd customers saw a triple-digit increase in their total June bills, the utility said.

“It’s a double whammy when you think about capacity price auctions and a very hot, unusually hot June,” Brad Perkins, ComEd’s director of rates and revenue policy, told the Tribune.

ComEd had warned that the supply portion of the bill would go up about \$10.60 per month beginning in June because of last year’s electricity auction, which set a higher price for the utility. But the projected increase was a 12-month average, and most customers were hit with a much bigger hike as the summer air conditioning season kicked off with a bang.

Things could get even worse next year, based on another record rate increase at an annual capacity auction held Tuesday, which will set ComEd’s price beginning in June 2026.

The supply charge generally represents about half the monthly bill and does not benefit ComEd, which makes its profit on the delivery charges. The average residential ComEd customer pays about \$108 per month for the total bill across the full year, not including the projected \$10.60 supply charge increase, the utility said.

But the impact of the increased supply rate varies based on actual

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OZZY OSBOURNE
1948-2025



BRIAN CASSELLA/TRIBUNE 2012

Singer pioneered heavy metal

The gloomy, demon-invoking lead singer of Black Sabbath who showed a softer side on TV’s “Osbournes” died Tuesday. **Page 10**



Loop buildings locked down

The Dirksen U.S. Courthouse was evacuated and on lockdown Tuesday as law enforcement talked with a man who walked in armed with a knife and threatened to hurt himself. The incident began shortly before 11 a.m., and sources told the Tribune at one point the man demanded to speak with the FBI. At left, a police officer tells a jogger to make a detour around the courthouse. **Page 6**

JOHN J. KIM/CHICAGO TRIBUNE

Time to head off to sundae school

The origin story behind the ice cream treat is swirled with mystery and history. Plus, six standout offerings in the area. **Food & Health**

Bears coach means business — right now

As the Bears begin training camp, Ben Johnson is setting an urgent tone. Plus, Brad Biggs on reasons to be optimistic. **Chicago Sports**

